stairwells of the home of cricket, I can hear them already. My spikes, out of the dressing room first, set off a harsh clashing of sounds as they ping against the echoing interior of the pavilion. This time, though, they do not clatter with the same endless delay. The sound is soaked up by the hum of people, the acoustics warmer, more rounded. The members are packed in at the bottom, already waiting, already applauding. They will be there, in the same fashion, every time I walk these stairs for the next few days, applauding and whooping loudly on sight every time I'm there. It is then that it occurs to me, just as it had as I walked in through the Harris Garden this morning, dropped off at Gate 6 as always, Joe Root next to me with a coffee as television cameras manically walked backwards to track our steps in – it doesn't actually even matter what happens here, does it? The victory has been won many times. I've already achieved everything I would have liked to, and more.

At the bottom of the stairs, I peer out, waiting for the introduction that has been cued up. The sky is moody out there, almost mournful, with clouds hanging low against North London, setting a grey backdrop across the ground that, as I lean out of the Long Room to look out on to a field so familiar yet, today, so foreign. I can see that the place is almost full, and then hear that same voice I've been hearing here for years over the PA, the tinniness of the tannoy that's always slightly more piercing than you would like it to be, but now somehow twice as loud as it's ever been, bouncing across Lord's.

'Playing for England under his eighth prime minister,' it begins, as a multitude of different statistics and measurements of time via wickets and Test matches disappear into the air. I'm just standing there, half apologising to everyone with the look on my face. This is like the surprise birthday party I never wanted, blown up into some sort of collision with the end of *The Truman Show* as the narrator explains back my life to me through a storm. Then, there's the video; all I can catch, leaning out, is the sound of it, set against commentary and wickets over the years, the sound of stumps clattering again and again, repeated and repeated, edges of a ball being nicked, the softness of the ball landing inside a slip fielder's hands. All those sounds that marked something sweet, the only thing I've strived for, played out on repeat one last time in cinematic vision. It feels like everyone I've ever known is there too, watching back on slow-motion replay. Once